

Forming arguments

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

The content of what you say in a GD matters as much as how you say it, and the difference between a forgettable point and a memorable one is almost always structure. An unstructured opinion ('I think AI will take away jobs') is easy for evaluators to forget and easy for other participants to dismiss; a structured argument with a clear claim, reasoning, and example is not. This sub-module teaches a repeatable framework for building arguments on the fly — even on topics you've never specifically prepared for — along with techniques for weighing both sides before committing to a stance, using data credibly without fabricating statistics, and anticipating the most obvious counterargument so you're not caught flat-footed when someone raises it.

1. The CEE Framework: Claim, Evidence, Example

A well-formed argument has three parts: a claim (the specific point you're making, stated as a clear sentence, not a vague gesture at a topic), evidence or reasoning (why the claim is true — a mechanism, a piece of data, or logical reasoning), and an example (a concrete instance that makes the abstract claim tangible). Skipping the example is the most common shortcut, and it's exactly what makes points forgettable. Applying this to a real topic: Claim — 'Gig economy work increases income flexibility but reduces financial security.' Evidence — 'Because workers aren't guaranteed steady hours or benefits like provident fund contributions.' Example — 'A delivery partner might earn well during festival season but have no fallback during a slow month, unlike a salaried employee.'

2. Taking a Stance Without Being Rigid

A common mistake is either refusing to commit to a stance ('there are pros and cons to both sides,' repeated without ever landing anywhere) or committing so rigidly that you can't acknowledge a fair counterpoint. The stronger approach is a qualified stance: take a clear position, but scope it precisely rather than universally. Instead of 'Remote work is better than office work' (too absolute, easy to counter), say 'Remote work improves output for individually-scoped tasks, but office presence still matters for early-career mentorship and spontaneous collaboration' — a stance that is both clear and defensible because it's scoped rather than absolute.

3. Weighing Both Sides Before You Speak

Before jumping in, briefly running through the strongest argument on each side of a topic — even mentally, in the seconds before you speak — produces a much sharper contribution than reacting to only the first angle that comes to mind. For an unfamiliar topic, a fast mental checklist helps: who benefits, who's harmed, what's the short-term effect versus the long-term effect, and is there a relevant recent example or data point. This preparation doesn't need to be exhaustive — even 10-15 seconds of structured thinking before speaking produces noticeably more balanced, credible arguments than speaking on pure reflex.

4. Using Data and Examples Credibly

Citing a statistic makes an argument feel more credible, but fabricating a precise-sounding number ('72% of companies reported this') when you don't actually know it is a real risk — a sharp panelist may ask where that number came from, and being caught improvising a false statistic damages credibility far more than not citing one at all. The safer approach is directional, honestly-hedged framing: 'A lot of companies reported productivity gains after shifting remote, especially in the IT sector' conveys the same point without inventing false precision. Real examples from personal experience, current events you actually know, or well-known cases (a company, a policy, a widely-reported trend) are safer and often more persuasive than invented statistics.

- Risky: 'Studies show 68% of remote workers are more productive.' (invented precision, easily challenged)
- Safer and still persuasive: 'Several large IT companies reported productivity holding steady or improving during remote work, though this varied a lot by role and team.'

5. Anticipating the Obvious Counterargument

Strong arguments in a GD often pre-empt the most obvious objection rather than waiting for someone else to raise it — doing so both strengthens your point and signals you've thought it through from multiple angles. This is done with a simple structure: state your claim, then acknowledge the counterpoint, then explain why your claim still holds despite it. For example: 'Remote work does reduce spontaneous mentorship moments, which is a real cost — but this can be partly offset with structured onboarding programs and scheduled 1:1 mentoring, so it's a solvable problem rather than a fundamental flaw.'

6. Building On Others' Arguments Instead of Repeating Them

As a GD progresses, the risk of repeating a point someone already made increases — and simply restating an existing point (even in different words) adds little value and can read as not having listened. The stronger move is explicitly building on a prior point: agreeing with part of it, extending it with a new angle, applying it to a different context, or offering a counter-example. Referencing the previous speaker by name when doing this ('Building on what Ananya said about urban markets, I think the same logic applies even more strongly to tier-2 cities because...') signals active listening and adds visible structure to the group's overall discussion.

7. Language Patterns That Signal Structured Thinking

Certain phrasing habits make an argument sound more structured even before the content is evaluated: explicitly signposting ('There are two angles here — the economic one and the social one'), using precise qualifiers instead of absolutes ('in most cases' rather than 'always'), and explicitly separating short-term from long-term effects. These aren't tricks to fake substance — they're organizing language that makes genuinely good reasoning easier for a listener to follow and credit.

- Signposting: 'I'd split this into two parts — the impact on employees, and the impact on the company.'
- Precise qualifier: 'In most cost-sensitive industries, this tends to hold — though it's less true in sectors with strong union protections.'

Common Pitfalls

- Stating an opinion with no reasoning or example, making it easy to forget or dismiss.
- Refusing to take any clear stance, hedging so much the point never lands.
- Taking an absolute, unscoped stance ('X is always better than Y') that's trivially easy to counter.
- Fabricating a precise-sounding statistic to sound credible, risking being challenged and caught.
- Repeating a point someone already made without adding a new angle, example, or extension.
- Reacting to only the first angle that comes to mind instead of briefly weighing both sides first.
- Never acknowledging an obvious counterargument, leaving your position looking one-sided.

Key Takeaways

- Use claim, evidence, example every time you speak — the example is what makes a point memorable.
- Take a scoped, qualified stance rather than either refusing to commit or overcommitting to an absolute.
- Briefly weigh both sides before speaking, even mentally, for 10-15 seconds.
- Prefer honest, directional framing over invented precise statistics — credibility survives being challenged, fabrication doesn't.
- Pre-empt the obvious counterargument yourself rather than waiting for someone else to raise it.
- Build explicitly on others' points by name instead of repeating or ignoring what's already been said.

Learn More

Harvard Business Review — The Argument-Driven Approach to Persuasion

<https://hbr.org/2013/07/a-4-step-process-for-winning-t>

MindTools — Critical Thinking Skills

<https://www.mindtools.com/ao8m8mp/critical-thinking>

Indeed — Group Discussion Topics and Tips

<https://www.indeed.com/career-advice/interviewing/group-discussion>